

For the use only of a Registered Medical Practitioner or a Hospital or a Laboratory

Irbemac H 300/12.5 Tablet (Irbesartan 300mg & Hydrochlorothiazide 12.5mg)

Irbemac H 300/25 Tablet (Irbesartan 300mg & Hydrochlorothiazide 25mg)

COMPOSITION:

Each film coated tablet contains:

Irbesartan Ph.Eur	300 mg
Hydrochlorothiazide Ph.Eur	12.5 mg

Each film coated tablet contains:

Irbesartan Ph.Eur	300 mg
Hydrochlorothiazide Ph.Eur	25 mg

DESCRIPTION:

300/12.5 mg: Peach coloured, oval, film coated tablets debossed with “ML 33” on one side and plain on other side.

300/25 mg: Pink coloured, oval, film coated tablets debossed with “ML 32” on one side and plain on other side.

PHARMACOKINETICS

Concomitant administration of Hydrochlorothiazide and Irbesartan has no effect on the pharmacokinetics of either medicinal product.

Irbesartan and hydrochlorothiazide are orally active agents and do not require biotransformation for their activity. Following oral administration of irbesartan/hydrochlorothiazide, the absolute oral bioavailability is 60-80 % and 50-80 % for irbesartan and hydrochlorothiazide, respectively. Food does not affect the bioavailability of irbesartan/hydrochlorothiazide. Peak plasma concentration occurs at 1.5-2 hours after oral administration for irbesartan and 1-2.5 hours for hydrochlorothiazide.

Plasma protein binding of irbesartan is approximately 96 %, with negligible binding to cellular blood components. The volume of distribution for irbesartan is 53-93 litres.

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Hydrochlorothiazide is 68 % protein-bound in the plasma, and its apparent volume of distribution is 0.83-1.14 l/kg.

Irbesartan exhibits linear and dose proportional pharmacokinetics. The total body and renal clearance are 157-176 and 3.0-3.5 ml/min, respectively. The terminal elimination half-life of irbesartan is 11-15 hours. Steady-state plasma concentrations are attained within 3 days after initiation of a once-daily dosing regimen. Limited accumulation of irbesartan (< 20 %) is observed in plasma upon repeated once-daily dosing. The mean plasma half-life of hydrochlorothiazide reportedly ranges from 5-15 hours.

Irbesartan and its metabolites are eliminated by both biliary and renal pathways. Hydrochlorothiazide is not metabolized but is eliminated rapidly by the kidneys.

At least 61 % of the oral dose is eliminated unchanged within 24 hours. Hydrochlorothiazide crosses the placental but not the blood-brain barrier, and is excreted in breast milk.

Renal impairment: in patients with renal impairment or those undergoing haemodialysis, the pharmacokinetic parameters of irbesartan are not significantly altered. Irbesartan is not removed by haemodialysis. In patients with creatinine clearance < 20 ml/min, the elimination half-life of hydrochlorothiazide was reported to increase to 21 hours.

Hepatic impairment: in patients with mild to moderate cirrhosis, the pharmacokinetic parameters of irbesartan are not significantly altered. Studies have not been performed in patients with severe hepatic impairment.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

Pharmacotherapeutic group: angiotensin-II antagonists, combinations

ATC code: C09DA04.

Mechanism of action

Irbemac H is a combination of an angiotensin-II receptor antagonist, irbesartan, and a thiazide diuretic, hydrochlorothiazide. The combination of these ingredients has an additive antihypertensive effect, reducing blood pressure to a greater degree than either component alone.

Irbesartan is a potent, orally active, selective angiotensin-II receptor (AT1 subtype) antagonist. It is expected to block all actions of angiotensin-II mediated by the AT1 receptor, regardless of the source or route of synthesis of angiotensin-II. The selective antagonism of the angiotensin-II (AT1) receptors results in increases in plasma renin levels and angiotensin-II levels, and a decrease in plasma aldosterone concentration. Serum potassium levels are not significantly affected by irbesartan alone at the recommended doses in patients without risk of electrolyte imbalance. Irbesartan does not inhibit ACE (kininase-II), an enzyme which generates angiotensin-II and also degrades bradykinin into inactive metabolites. Irbesartan does not require metabolic activation for its activity.

Hydrochlorothiazide is a thiazide diuretic. The mechanism of antihypertensive effect of thiazide diuretics is not fully known. Thiazides affect the renal tubular mechanisms of electrolyte reabsorption, directly increasing excretion of sodium and chloride in approximately equivalent amounts. The diuretic action of hydrochlorothiazide reduces plasma volume, increases plasma renin activity, increases aldosterone secretion, with consequent increases in urinary potassium and bicarbonate loss, and decreases in serum potassium. Presumably through blockade of the renin-angiotensin-aldosterone system, co-administration of irbesartan tends to reverse the potassium loss associated with these diuretics. With hydrochlorothiazide, onset of diuresis occurs in 2 hours, and peak effect occurs at about 4 hours, while the action persists for approximately 6-12 hours.

The combination of hydrochlorothiazide and irbesartan produces dose-related additive reductions in blood pressure across their therapeutic dose ranges.

The blood pressure lowering effect of irbesartan in combination with hydrochlorothiazide is apparent after the first dose and substantially present within 1-2 weeks, with the maximal effect occurring by 6-8 weeks.

The effect of the combination of irbesartan and hydrochlorothiazide on morbidity and mortality has not been studied. Epidemiological studies have shown that long term treatment with hydrochlorothiazide reduces the risk of cardiovascular mortality and morbidity.

There is no difference in response to Irbema H, regardless of age or gender. As is the case with other medicinal products that affect the renin-angiotensin system, black hypertensive patients have notably less response to irbesartan monotherapy. When irbesartan is administered concomitantly with a low dose of hydrochlorothiazide (e.g. 12.5 mg daily), the antihypertensive response in black patients approaches that of non-black patients.

Dual blockade of the renin-angiotensin-aldosterone system (RAAS)

ACE-inhibitors and angiotensin II receptor blockers should not be used concomitantly in patients with diabetic nephropathy.

Non-melanoma skin cancer:

Based on available data from epidemiological studies, cumulative dose-dependent association between Hydrochlorothiazide and non melanoma skin cancer has been observed. One study included a population comprised of 71,533 cases of BCC and of 8,629 cases of sec matched to 1,430,833 and 172,462 population controls, respectively. High HCTZ use ($\geq 50,000$ mg cumulative) was associated with an adjusted OR of 1.29 (95% CI: 1.23-1.35) for BCC and 3.98 (95% CI: 3.68-4.31) for sec. A clear cumulative dose response relationship was observed for both BCC and SCC. Another study showed a possible association between lip cancer (SCC) and exposure to HCTZ: 633 cases of lip-cancer were matched with 63,067 population controls, using a risk-set sampling strategy. A cumulative dose-response relationship was demonstrated with an adjusted OR 2.1 (95% CI: 1.7-2.6) increasing to OR 3.9 (3.0-4.9) for high use ($\geq 25,000$ mg) and OR 7.7 (5.7-10.5) for the highest cumulative dose ($\geq 100,000$ mg).

INDICATIONS AND USAGE:

Treatment of essential hypertension.

This fixed dose combination is indicated in patients whose blood pressure is not adequately controlled on irbesartan or hydrochlorothiazide alone.

CONTRAINDICATIONS:

- In patients who are hypertensive the active substances or to any of the components or to any component of this product and other sulfonamide-derived substances (hydrochlorothiazide is a sulfonamide-derived substance)
- Second and third trimesters of pregnancy
- Severe renal impairment (creatinine clearance < 30 ml/min)
- Refractory hypokalaemia, hypercalcaemia
- Severe hepatic impairment, biliary cirrhosis and cholestasis
- concomitant use of Irbemac H tablet with aliskiren-containing products is contraindicated in patients with diabetes mellitus or renal impairment (glomerular filtration rate (GFR) <60 ml/min/1.73 m²)

ADVERSE REACTION:

The most commonly reported adverse drug reactions are dizziness, fatigue, nausea/vomiting, and abnormal urination, increases in blood urea nitrogen (BUN), creatine kinase and creatinine. The frequency of adverse reactions listed below is defined using the following convention: very common; common; uncommon; rare; very rare.

<i>Investigations</i>	Common	increases in blood urea nitrogen (BUN), creatinine and creatine kinase
	Uncommon	decreases in serum potassium and sodium
<i>Cardiac disorder</i>	Uncommon	syncope, hypotension, tachycardia, oedema
<i>Nervous system disorders</i>	Common	dizziness
	Uncommon	orthostatic dizziness
	Not known	headache
<i>Ear and labyrinth disorders</i>	Not known	tinnitus
<i>Respiratory, thoracic and</i>	Not known	cough

<i>mediastinal disorders</i>		
<i>Gastrointestinal disorder:</i>	Common	nausea/vomiting
	Uncommon	diarrhoea
	Not known	dyspepsia, dysgeusia
<i>Renal and urinary disorders</i>	Common	abnormal urination
	Not known	impaired renal function including isolated cases of renal failure in patients at risk
<i>Musculoskeletal and connective tissue disorders</i>	Uncommon	swelling extremity
	Not known	arthralgia, myalgia
<i>Metabolism and nutrition disorders</i>	Not known	hyperkalaemia
<i>Vascular disorder:</i>	Uncommon	flushing
<i>General disorders and administration site conditions</i>	Common	fatigue
<i>Immune system disorders</i>	Not known	cases of hypersensitivity reactions such as angioedema, rash, urticaria
<i>Hepatobiliary disorders</i>	Uncommon	jaundice
	Not known	hepatitis, abnormal liver function
<i>Reproductive system and breast disorders</i>	Uncommon	sexual dysfunction, libido changes
<i>Neoplasms benign, malignant and unspecified (incl cysts and polyps)</i>	Not known	Non-melanoma skin cancer (Basal cell carcinoma and Squamous cell carcinoma)

Additional information on individual components: in addition to the adverse reactions listed above for the combination product, other adverse reactions previously reported with one of the individual components may be potential adverse reactions with Irbemac H Tablets. Tables below detail the adverse reactions reported with the individual components of Irbemac H Tablets

Adverse Reactions reported with the use of irbesartan alone		
<i>Blood and lymphatic system disorders</i>	Not known	thrombocytopenia
<i>Generic disorders and administration site conditions</i>	Uncommon	chest pain
<i>Immune system disorders</i>	Not known	Anaphylactic reaction including anaphylactic shock

Adverse reactions reported with the use of hydrochlorothiazide alone		
<i>Investigations</i>	Not known	electrolyte imbalance (including hypokalaemia and hyponatraemia, (see warnings and precautions), hyperuricaemia, glycosuria, hyperglycaemia, increases in cholesterol and triglycerides
<i>Cardiac disorders</i>	Not known	cardiac arrhythmias
<i>Blood and lymphatic system disorders</i>	Not known	aplastic anaemia, bone marrow depression, neutropenia/agranulocytosis, haemolytic anaemia, leucopenia, thrombocytopenia
<i>Nervous system disorders</i>	Not known	vertigo, paraesthesia, light-headedness, restlessness
<i>Eye disorders</i>	Not known	transient blurred vision, xanthopsia, acute myopia and secondary acute angle-closure glaucoma

<i>Respiratory, thoracic and mediastinal disorders</i>	Not known	respiratory distress (including pneumonitis and pulmonary oedema)
<i>Gastrointestinal disorders</i>	Not known	pancreatitis, anorexia, diarrhoea, constipation, gastric irritation, sialadenitis, loss of appetite
<i>Renal and urinary disorders</i>	Not known	interstitial nephritis, renal dysfunction
<i>Skin and subcutaneous tissue disorders</i>	Not known	anaphylactic reactions, toxic epidermal necrolysis, necrotizing angitis (vasculitis, cutaneous vasculitis), cutaneous lupus erythematosus-like reactions, reactivation of cutaneous lupus erythematosus, photosensitivity reactions, rash, urticaria
<i>Musculoskeletal and connective tissue disorders</i>	Not known	weakness, muscle spasm
<i>Vascular disorders</i>	Not known	postural hypotension
<i>General disorders and administration site</i>	Not known	fever
<i>Hepatobiliary disorders</i>	Not known	jaundice (intrahepatic cholestatic jaundice)
<i>Psychiatric disorders</i>	Not known	depression, sleep disturbances
<i>Neoplasms benign, malignant and unspecified (incl cysts and polyps)</i>	Not known	non-melanoma skin cancer (basal cell carcinoma and squamous cell carcinoma)

Description of selected adverse reactions

Non-melanoma skin cancer: Based on available data from epidemiological studies, cumulative dose-dependent association between HCTZ and NMSC has been observed.

DOSAGE:

Irbemac H Tablet can be taken once daily, with or without food.

Dose titration with the individual components (i.e. irbesartan and hydrochlorothiazide) may be recommended.

When clinically appropriate direct change from monotherapy to the fixed combinations may be considered:

- Irbema H 300 mg/12.5 mg may be administered in patients insufficiently controlled by irbesartan 300 mg
- Irbema H 300 mg/25 mg may be administered in patients insufficiently controlled by Irbema H 300 mg/12.5 mg.

Doses higher than 300 mg irbesartan/25 mg hydrochlorothiazide once daily are not recommended.

When necessary, Irbema H tablet may be administered with another antihypertensive medicinal product.

Renal impairment: due to the hydrochlorothiazide component, Irbema H tablet is not recommended for patients with severe renal dysfunction (creatinine clearance < 30 ml/min). Loop diuretics are preferred to thiazides in this population. No dosage adjustment is necessary in patients with renal impairment whose renal creatinine clearance is ≥ 30 ml/min.

Hepatic impairment: Irbema H tablet is not indicated in patients with severe hepatic impairment. Thiazides should be used with caution in patients with impaired hepatic function.

No dosage adjustment of Irbema H tablet is necessary in patients with mild to moderate hepatic impairment.

Elderly patients: no dosage adjustment of Irbema H tablet is necessary in older patients.

Paediatric patients: Irbema H tablet is not recommended for use in children and adolescents due to lack of data on safety and efficacy.

Mode of Administration:

For oral use.

DRUG INTERACTIONS:

Other antihypertensive agents: The antihypertensive effect of Irbema H may be increased with the concomitant use of other antihypertensive agents. Irbesartan and hydrochlorothiazide (at doses up to 300 mg irbesartan/25 mg hydrochlorothiazide) have been safely administered with other antihypertensive agents including calcium channel blockers and beta-adrenergic blockers.

Prior treatment with high dose diuretics may result in volume depletion and a risk of hypotension when initiating therapy with irbesartan with or without thiazide diuretics unless the volume depletion is corrected first

Aliskiren-containing products or ACE-inhibitors: Dual blockade of the renin-angiotensin-aldosterone system (RAAS) through the combined use of ACE-inhibitors, angiotensin II receptor blockers or aliskiren is associated with a higher frequency of adverse events such as hypotension, hyperkalaemia and decreased renal function (including acute renal failure) compared to the use of a single RAAS-acting agent.

Lithium: Reversible increases in serum lithium concentrations and toxicity have been reported during concomitant administration of lithium with angiotensin converting enzyme inhibitors. Similar effects have been very rarely reported with irbesartan so far. Furthermore, renal clearance of lithium is reduced by thiazides so the risk of lithium toxicity could be increased with Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablet. Therefore, the combination of lithium and Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablet is not recommended. If the combination proves necessary, careful monitoring of serum lithium levels is recommended.

Medicinal products affecting potassium: The potassium-depleting effect of hydrochlorothiazide is attenuated by the potassium-sparing effect of irbesartan. However, this effect of hydrochlorothiazide on serum potassium would be expected to be potentiated by other medicinal products associated with potassium loss and hypokalaemia (e.g. other kaliuretic diuretics, laxatives, amphotericin, carbenoxolone, penicillin G sodium). Conversely, based on the experience with the use of other medicinal products that blunt the renin-angiotensin system, concomitant use of potassium-sparing diuretics, potassium supplements, salt substitutes containing potassium or other medicinal products that may increase serum potassium levels (e.g. heparin sodium) may lead to increases in serum potassium. Adequate monitoring of serum potassium in patients at risk is recommended.

Medicinal products affected by serum potassium disturbances: Periodic monitoring of serum potassium is recommended when Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablet is administered with medicinal products affected by serum potassium disturbances (e.g. digitalis glycosides, antiarrhythmics).

Non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs: When angiotensin II antagonists are administered simultaneously with non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (i.e. selective COX-2 inhibitors, acetylsalicylic acid (> 3 g/day) and non-selective NSAIDs), attenuation of the antihypertensive effect may occur.

As with ACE inhibitors, concomitant use of angiotensin II antagonists and NSAIDs may lead to an increased risk of worsening of renal function, including possible acute renal failure, and an increase in serum potassium, especially in patients with poor pre-existing renal function. The combination should be administered with caution, especially in the elderly. Patients should be adequately hydrated and consideration should be given to monitoring renal function after initiation of concomitant therapy, and periodically thereafter.

Additional information on irbesartan interactions: The pharmacokinetic of irbesartan is not affected by hydrochlorothiazide. Irbesartan is mainly metabolised by CYP2C9 and to a lesser extent by glucuronidation. No significant pharmacokinetic or pharmacodynamic interactions is observed when irbesartan was coadministered with warfarin, a medicinal product metabolised by CYP2C9. The effects of CYP2C9 inducers such as rifampicin on the pharmacokinetic of irbesartan are not evaluated. The pharmacokinetic of digoxin is not altered by co-administration of irbesartan.

Additional information on hydrochlorothiazide interactions: when administered concurrently, the following medicinal products may interact with thiazide diuretics:

Alcohol: potentiation of orthostatic hypotension may occur;

Antidiabetic medicinal products (oral agents and insulins): dosage adjustment of the antidiabetic medicinal product may be required;

Colestyramine and Colestipol resins: absorption of hydrochlorothiazide is impaired in the presence of anionic exchange resins. Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablet should be taken at least one hour before or four hours after these medications;

Corticosteroids, ACTH: electrolyte depletion, particularly hypokalaemia, may be increased;

Digitalis glycosides: thiazide induced hypokalaemia or hypomagnesaemia favour the onset of digitalis-induced cardiac arrhythmias;

Non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs: the administration of a non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drug may reduce the diuretic, natriuretic and antihypertensive effects of thiazide diuretics in some patients;

Pressor amines (e.g. noradrenaline): the effect of pressor amines may be decreased, but not sufficiently to preclude their use;

Nondepolarizing skeletal muscle relaxants (e.g. tubocurarine): the effect of nondepolarizing skeletal muscle relaxants may be potentiated by hydrochlorothiazide;

Antigout medicinal products: dosage adjustments of antigout medicinal products may be necessary as hydrochlorothiazide may raise the level of serum uric acid. Increase in dosage of probenecid or sulfinpyrazone may be necessary. Co-administration of thiazide diuretics may increase the incidence of hypersensitivity reactions to allopurinol;

Calcium salts: thiazide diuretics may increase serum calcium levels due to decreased excretion. If calcium supplements or calcium sparing medicinal products (e.g. vitamin D therapy) must be prescribed, serum calcium levels should be monitored and calcium dosage adjusted accordingly;

Carbamazepine: concomitant use of carbamazepine and hydrochlorothiazide has been associated with the risk of symptomatic hyponatraemia. Electrolytes should be monitored during concomitant use. If possible, another class of diuretics should be used;

Other interactions: the hyperglycaemic effect of beta-blockers and diazoxide may be enhanced by thiazides. Anticholinergic agents (e.g. atropine, beperiden) may increase the bioavailability of thiazide-type diuretics by decreasing gastrointestinal motility and stomach emptying rate. Thiazides may increase the risk of adverse effects caused by amantadine. Thiazides may reduce the renal excretion of cytotoxic medicinal products (e.g. cyclophosphamide, methotrexate) and potentiate their myelosuppressive effects.

PREGNANCY AND LACTATION :

Pregnancy

Angiotensin II Receptor Antagonists (AIIRAs)

The use of AIIRAs is not recommended during the first trimester of pregnancy. The use of AIIRAs is contraindicated during the second and third trimesters of pregnancy.

Epidemiological evidence regarding the risk of teratogenicity following exposure to ACE inhibitors during the first trimester of pregnancy has not been conclusive; however a small increase in risk cannot be excluded. Whilst there is no controlled epidemiological data on the risk with Angiotensin II Receptor Antagonists (AIIRAs), similar risks may exist for this class of drugs. Unless continued AIIRA therapy is considered essential, patients planning pregnancy should be changed to alternative antihypertensive treatments which have an established safety profile for use in pregnancy. When pregnancy is diagnosed, treatment with AIIRAs should be stopped immediately, and, if appropriate, alternative therapy should be started. Exposure to AIIRA therapy during the second and third trimesters is known to induce human foetotoxicity (decreased renal function, oligohydramnios, skull ossification retardation) and neonatal toxicity (renal failure, hypotension, hyperkalaemia). Should exposure to AIIRAs have occurred from the second trimester of pregnancy, ultrasound check of renal function and skull is recommended. Infants whose mothers have taken AIIRAs should be closely observed for hypotension

Hydrochlorothiazide

There is limited experience with hydrochlorothiazide during pregnancy, especially during the first trimester. Animal studies are insufficient. Hydrochlorothiazide crosses the placenta. Based on the pharmacological mechanism of action of hydrochlorothiazide its use during the second and third trimester may compromise foeto-placental perfusion and may cause foetal and neonatal effects like icterus, disturbance of electrolyte balance and thrombocytopenia. Hydrochlorothiazide should not be used for gestational oedema, gestational hypertension or preeclampsia due to the risk of decreased plasma volume and placental hypoperfusion, without a beneficial effect on the course of the disease. Hydrochlorothiazide should not be used for essential hypertension in pregnant women except in rare situations where no other treatment could be used.

Since Irbemac H contains hydrochlorothiazide, it is not recommended during the first trimester of pregnancy. A switch to a suitable alternative treatment should be carried out in advance of a planned pregnancy.

Breast-feeding

Angiotensin II Receptor Antagonists (AIIRAs)

Because no information is available regarding the use of Irbamac H during breast-feeding, Irbamac H is not recommended and alternative treatments with better established safety profiles during breast-feeding are preferable, especially while nursing a newborn or preterm infant. It is unknown whether irbesartan or its metabolites are excreted in human milk.

Hydrochlorothiazide

Hydrochlorothiazide is excreted in human milk in small amounts. Thiazides in high doses causing intense diuresis can inhibit the milk production. The use of Irbamac H during breast feeding is not recommended. If Irbamac H is used during breast feeding, doses should be kept as low as possible.

Fertility

Irbesartan had no effect upon fertility of treated rats and their offspring up to the dose levels inducing the first signs of parental toxicity

WARNING & PRECAUTION:

Hypotension - Volume-depleted patients: Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets has been rarely associated with symptomatic hypotension in hypertensive patients without other risk factors for hypotension. Symptomatic hypotension may be expected to occur in patients who are volume and/or sodium depleted by vigorous diuretic therapy, dietary salt restriction, diarrhoea or vomiting. Such conditions should be corrected before initiating therapy with Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets.

Renal artery stenosis - Renovascular hypertension: there is an increased risk of severe hypotension and renal insufficiency when patients with bilateral renal artery stenosis or stenosis of the artery to a single functioning kidney are treated with angiotensin converting enzyme inhibitors or angiotensin-II receptor antagonists. While this is not documented with Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets, a similar effect should be anticipated.

Renal impairment and kidney transplantation: When Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets is used in patients with impaired renal function, a periodic monitoring of potassium, creatinine and uric acid serum levels is recommended. There is no experience regarding the administration of Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets in patients with recent kidney transplantation. Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets should not be used in patients with severe renal impairment (creatinine clearance < 30 ml/min). Thiazide diuretic-associated azotemia may occur in patients with impaired renal function. In patients with mild to moderate renal impairment (creatinine clearance $\geq$ 30 ml/min but < 60 ml/min) this fixed dose combination should be administered with caution.

Dual blockade of the renin-angiotensin-aldosterone system (RAAS):

There is evidence that the concomitant use of ACE-inhibitors, angiotensin II receptor blockers or aliskiren increases the risk of hypotension, hyperkalaemia and decreased renal function (including acute renal failure). Dual blockade of RAAS through the combined use of ACE-inhibitors, angiotensin II receptor blockers or aliskiren is therefore not recommended. If dual blockade therapy is considered absolutely necessary, this should only occur under specialist supervision and subject to frequent close monitoring of renal function, electrolytes and blood pressure. ACE-inhibitors and angiotensin II receptor blockers should not be used concomitantly in patients with diabetic nephropathy.

Hepatic impairment: Thiazides should be used with caution in patients with impaired hepatic function or progressive liver disease, since minor alterations of fluid and electrolyte balance may precipitate hepatic coma. There is no clinical experience with Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets in patients with hepatic impairment.

Aortic and mitral valve stenosis, obstructive hypertrophic cardiomyopathy: As with other vasodilators, special caution is indicated in patients suffering from aortic or mitral stenosis, or obstructive hypertrophic cardiomyopathy.

Primary aldosteronism: Patients with primary aldosteronism generally will not respond to antihypertensive medicinal products acting through inhibition of the renin-angiotensin system. Therefore, the use of Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets is not recommended.

Metabolic and endocrine effects: Thiazide therapy may impair glucose tolerance. In diabetic patients dosage adjustments of insulin or oral hypoglycemic agents may be required. Latent diabetes mellitus may become manifest during thiazide therapy.

Increases in cholesterol and triglyceride levels have been associated with thiazide diuretic therapy; however at the 12.5 mg dose contained in Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets, minimal or no effects occur.

Hyperuricaemia may occur or frank gout may be precipitated in certain patients receiving thiazide therapy.

Electrolyte imbalance: as for any patient receiving diuretic therapy, periodic determination of serum electrolytes should be performed at appropriate intervals.

Thiazides, including hydrochlorothiazide, can cause fluid or electrolyte imbalance (hypokalaemia, hyponatraemia, and hypochloremic alkalosis). Warning signs of fluid or electrolyte imbalance are dryness of mouth, thirst, weakness, lethargy, drowsiness, restlessness, muscle pain or cramps, muscular fatigue, hypotension, oliguria, tachycardia, and gastrointestinal disturbances such as nausea or vomiting.

Although hypokalaemia may develop with the use of thiazide diuretics, concurrent therapy with irbesartan may reduce diuretic-induced hypokalaemia. The risk of hypokalaemia is greatest in patients with cirrhosis of the liver, in patients experiencing brisk diuresis, in patients who are receiving inadequate oral intake of electrolytes and in patients receiving concomitant therapy with corticosteroids or ACTH. Conversely, due to the irbesartan component of Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets hyperkalaemia might occur, especially in the presence of renal impairment and/or heart failure, and diabetes mellitus. Adequate monitoring of serum potassium in patients at risk is recommended. Potassium-sparing diuretics, potassium supplements or potassium-containing salts substitutes should be co-administered cautiously with Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets.

There is no evidence that irbesartan would reduce or prevent diuretic-induced hyponatraemia. Chloride deficit is generally mild and usually does not require treatment.

Thiazides may decrease urinary calcium excretion and cause an intermittent and slight elevation of serum calcium in the absence of known disorders of calcium metabolism. Marked hypercalcaemia may be evidence of hidden hyperparathyroidism. Thiazides should be discontinued before carrying out tests for parathyroid function.

Thiazides have been shown to increase the urinary excretion of magnesium, which may result in hypomagnesaemia.

Lithium: The combination of lithium and Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets is not recommended.

Anti-doping test: Hydrochlorothiazide contained in this medicinal product could produce a positive analytic result in an anti-doping test.

General: In patients whose vascular tone and renal function depend predominantly on the activity of the renin-angiotensin-aldosterone system (e.g. patients with severe congestive heart failure or underlying renal disease, including renal artery stenosis), treatment with angiotensin converting enzyme inhibitors or angiotensin-II receptor antagonists that affect this system has been associated with acute hypotension, azotemia, oliguria, or rarely acute renal failure. As with any antihypertensive agent, excessive blood pressure decrease in patients with ischemic cardiopathy or ischemic cardiovascular disease could result in a myocardial infarction or stroke.

Hypersensitivity reactions to hydrochlorothiazide may occur in patients with or without a history of allergy or bronchial asthma, but are more likely in patients with such a history.

Exacerbation or activation of systemic lupus erythematosus has been reported with the use of thiazide diuretics.

Cases of photosensitivity reactions have been reported with thiazides diuretics. If photosensitivity reaction occurs during treatment, it is recommended to stop the treatment. If a re-administration of the diuretic is deemed necessary, it is recommended to protect exposed areas to the sun or to artificial UVA.

Pregnancy: Angiotensin II Receptor Antagonists (AIIRAs) should not be initiated during pregnancy. Unless continued AIIRA therapy is considered essential, patients planning pregnancy should be changed to alternative antihypertensive treatments which have an established safety profile for use in pregnancy. When pregnancy is diagnosed, treatment with AIIRAs should be stopped immediately, and, if appropriate, alternative therapy should be started.

Acute Myopia and Secondary Acute Angle-Closure Glaucoma: Sulfonamide drugs or sulfonamide derivative drugs can cause an idiosyncratic reaction, resulting in transient myopia and acute angle-closure glaucoma. While hydrochlorothiazide is a sulfonamide, only isolated

cases of acute angle-closure glaucoma have been reported so far with hydrochlorothiazide. Symptoms include acute onset of decreased visual acuity or ocular pain and typically occur within hours to weeks of drug initiation. Untreated acute angle-closure glaucoma can lead to permanent vision loss. The primary treatment is to discontinue drug intake as rapidly as possible. Prompt medical or surgical treatments may need to be considered if the intraocular pressure remains uncontrolled. Risk factors for developing acute angle-closure glaucoma may include a history of sulfonamide or penicillin allergy.

Non-melanoma skin cancer: An increased risk of non-melanoma skin cancer (NMSC) [basal cell carcinoma (BCC) and squamous cell carcinoma (SCC)] with increasing cumulative dose of hydrochlorothiazide (HCTZ) exposure has been observed in two epidemiological studies based on the Danish National Cancer Registry. Photosensitizing actions of HCTZ could act as a possible mechanism for NMSC. Patients taking HCTZ should be informed of the risk of NMSC and advised to regularly check their skin for any new lesions and promptly report any suspicious skin lesions. Possible preventive measures, adequate protection should be advised to the patients in order to minimize the risk of skin cancer. Suspicious skin lesions should be promptly examined potentially including histological examinations of biopsies. The use of HCTZ may also need to be reconsidered in patients who have experienced previous NMSC.

OVERDOSE:

No specific information is available on the treatment of overdose with Irbesartan + Hydrochlorothiazide Tablets. The patient should be closely monitored, and the treatment should be symptomatic and supportive. Management depends on the time since ingestion and the severity of the symptoms. Suggested measures include induction of emesis and/or gastric lavage. Activated charcoal may be useful in the treatment of overdose. Serum electrolytes and creatinine should be monitored frequently. If hypotension occurs, the patient should be placed in a supine position, with salt and volume replacements given quickly.

The most likely manifestations of irbesartan overdose are expected to be hypotension and tachycardia; bradycardia might also occur.

Overdose with hydrochlorothiazide is associated with electrolyte depletion (hypokalaemia, hyponatraemia, hypochloremia) and dehydration resulting from excessive diuresis. The most common signs and symptoms of overdose are nausea and somnolence. Hypokalaemia may

result in muscle spasms and/or accentuate cardiac arrhythmias associated with the concomitant use of digitalis glycosides or certain anti-arrhythmic medicinal products.

Irbesartan is not removed by haemodialysis. The degree to which hydrochlorothiazide is removed by haemodialysis has not been established.

EFFECTS ON ABILITY TO DRIVE AND USE MACHINES:

No studies on the effects on the ability to drive and use machines have been performed. Based on its pharmacodynamic properties, IRBEMAC H is unlikely to affect this ability. When driving vehicles or operating machines, it should be taken into account that occasionally dizziness or weariness may occur during treatment of hypertension.

STORAGE:

Store below 30°C in a dry place. Protect from light.

KEEP OUT OF REACH OF CHILDREN.

PRESENTATION:

Alu / White opaque PVC/PE/PVdC Blister of 14 Tablets, Such 2 blisters packed in a carton along with the Pack Insert.

MANUFACTURED BY

MACLEODS PHARMACEUTICALS LTD.

Unit II, Plot No. 12, 15, 21, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28 & 30

Survey No. 366, Premier Industrial Estate,

Kachigam, 396 210 Daman, India.

Off.: Atlanta Arcade, Marol Church Road,

Andheri (E), Mumbai - 400 059.

PRODUCT REGISTRATION HOLDER

Synerrv Sdn Bhd,

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